

Mixanthropy: Holographic Metamorphic Clouds

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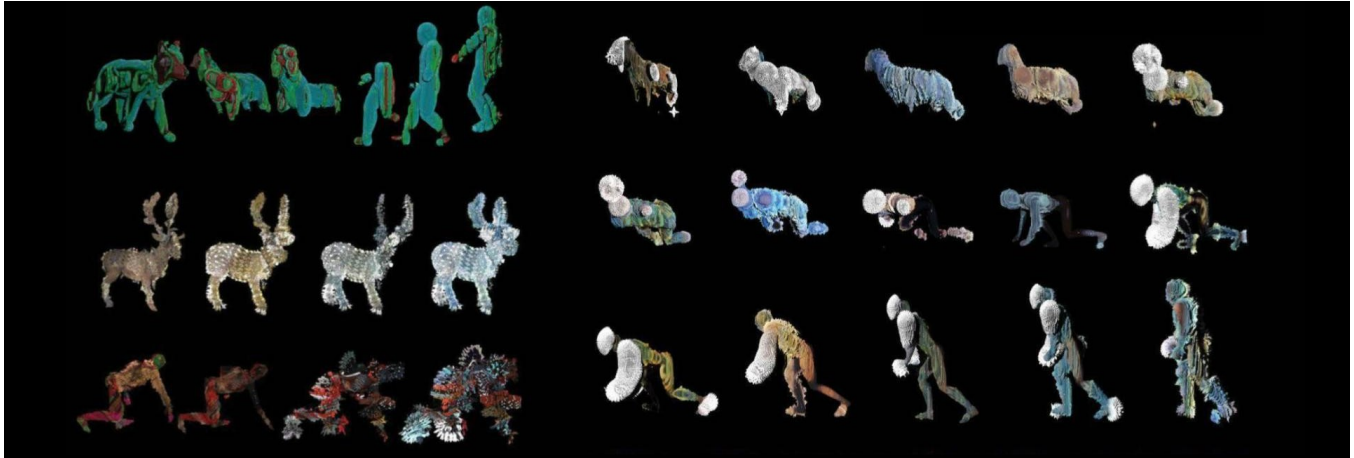


Figure 1: Mixanthropy, a Sequence of Frames Depicting the Metamorphic and Kinetic Procession from Animal to Human

Abstract

Mixanthropy is a holographic installation that invites viewers on a shapeshifting journey through human and nonhuman states. This work features digital chimeras that morph in response to the viewer's presence. It explores the body in transition, challenging anthropocentric boundaries and evoking a living, animistic space where form, identity, and consciousness remain in constant flux.

CCS Concepts

• Applied computing → Media arts.

Keywords

Hologram, Installation Art, Multimedia, Artificial Intelligence

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1 Introduction

As we blur the distinctions between human, animal and machine, we merge mythology with science fiction, as both are narratives of humanity's navigation through the unknown. Mixanthropy is a holographic installation that explores shape-shifting between human and nonhuman states through digital embodiment, motion, and myth. The term "Mixanthropy" is adapted from a Greek term *Mixanthrôpoi*[1], which refers to the capturing of a deity's potential for fluidity and change. Crossing boundaries between animal and human states, Mixanthropy explores divine hybridity through body transformations based on anatomical isomorphism, with mimetic skin textures echoing different AI-trained generative environments [2]. Each of the mixanthropes morphs into another body with motion tracking technology, registering the two artists' own choreography during which they imagined themselves inhabiting a non-human body. This work synchronizes motion, as an externalization of the intrinsic psyche [2], with visual deformation and metamorphosis, honoring constant boundary crossing as a mechanism of mind and aesthetics.

Hybridity and mythological archetypes arising from metamorphic bodies have been historical motifs from mythological pantheons of the world. Mixanthropy fits the mythological influences in the contemporary technocultural framework, creating conceptual and technological shapeshifters that break down the binary boundaries of animal-human, of organism-machine, and of mundane-sacred. Mixanthropes expand new frontiers of knowing and aesthetics understood not by category but by migration and metempsychosis.

By exploring the metamorphosis across anatomy, behavior and skin texture, and fluidity of identity of humans and animals, the

mixanthrope encompasses multiple properties. It is neither one object, nor one organism, but a mechanism of a mind that cannot be categorized but only rests in fluidity. As an observer, we see them change in time. But the metamorphic figure at every frame is a shade of the mind itself. It just manifests itself differently in different times and environments. The essence is that the mixanthrope incessantly reuptakes and renews different properties and exhibits different figures as shades of the mind. There seems to always be a relationship between hybridity and metamorphosis, as there is between mind (intrinsic) and motion (extrinsic).

2 Research Creation Approach

The creation process of Mixanthropy was interdisciplinary, bridging performance capture of animal-to-human choreography with OptiTrack, CG, human-animal skeletal mesh morphing in Houdini, and simulated satellite imaging as body texture with AI latent space video trained by StyleGAN. To visualize digital hybrids that encompass both human and non-human, living and non-living entities, our pipeline integrates avatar morphing with skeletal animation blending. The avatars' skin textures are generated from the time-varying image sequences derived from AI latent space walks across diverse ecological environments, inspired by the mimetic skin textures of animals like octopus that shift to match their environments.

In world mythology, hybrid forms and mythological archetypes linked to metamorphic bodies have been recurring motifs. An important difference between monsters and deities is manifested through the potential of shape-shifting. In the contemporary technoculture, such abilities can philosophically migrate to technologically-driven digital entities [3]. In our artistic approach, we blend CG, AI and performance from symbiosis to hybrid metamorphosis, with special attention to matching skeleton anatomy at points of morphing.

Therefore, we not only work with the visual, but also investigate cultural, biological and technological implications to inform our artistic approach and expression. With the increasing presence and application of technologies such as AI and biotechnology, definitions of what it means to be human are ever-changing. We hope to stimulate more discussions and incorporate multiple perspectives - that's why we delve into the more-than-human realm, from interspecies symbiosis to hybrid bodies, to dissolve the boundaries between human and animals, organics and synthetics.

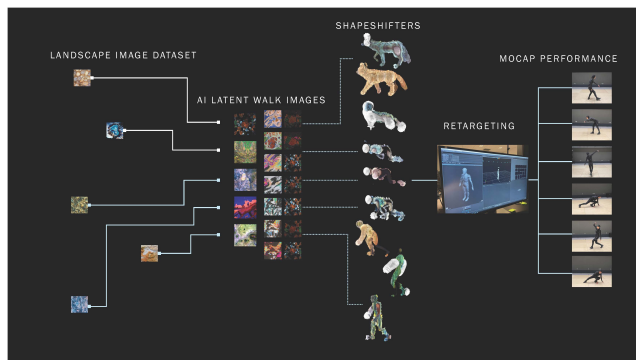


Figure 2: Workflow of Mixanthropy

3 Installation and Experience

The installation features a collection of suspended holographic displays, each presenting a digital chimera in a state of continuous metamorphosis between human and non-human bodies. These hybrid figures are inspired by mythological archetypes. The exhibition room will be dark and lit only by the morphing figures, for the viewer to wander in the forest of holograms, evoking the dual sense of watching and being watched by powerful ancient future spirits.

Each holographic figure subtly reacts to visitor movement, generating a sense of presence and animacy that blurs the line between digital creature and living entity. The presented work immerses visitors in a liminal perceptual experience, walking amidst the suspended pyramid holograms with float-in-air chimeras morphing in response to the motion sensor detecting the location of the audience. As holographic chimeras shift their form and movement in response to the visitor's presence, the installation evokes a sense of presence in animism and co-creation.

To accommodate the site conditions at the ACM MM venue, an alternative version of the work will be presented as a looping video on an LED display.

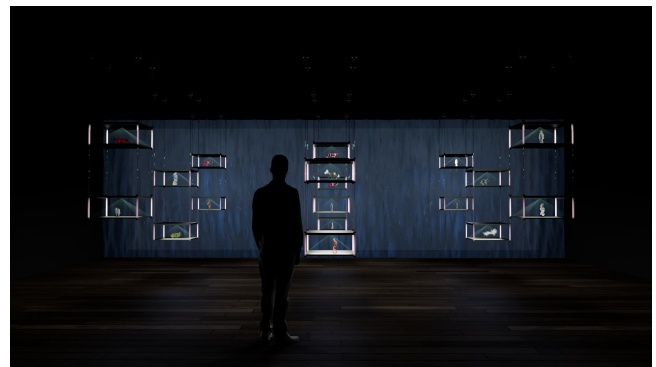


Figure 3: Pre-visualization of Holographic Installation

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